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Catholic 101: What is prayer? How do I pray?

By David Romero SJ, 15 September 2022



People in prayer during the Diocese of Parramatta World Youth Day pilgrimage launch at St John XXIII Catholic College, Stanhope Gardens.
Image: Diocese of Parramatta

Two common questions I had growing up as a Catholic were: “What is prayer?” and “How do I pray?” Fast-forward to today, when I am an ordained priest. And whether I’m on a retreat, at church after Mass, or really just about any other place (including getting a drink with friends!), I get these same questions.

Why do these questions keep coming up? Because they are great questions! They speak to our longing to grow closer to God, to be in a relationship. Prayer is an essential means to cultivating our relationship with God.

So let’s explore the fascinating topic of prayer. This article will explore both of these essential questions: What is prayer? And how do I pray?

What is prayer?

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for the comfort and security of a war-torn nation, a child asks for a good grade on a test, while an elderly person asks that God grant them a peaceful death. We pray for all sorts of things: safe travel, good physical health, financial security. At its best, this form of prayer acknowledges our limitations and our real need for God.

But can prayer look differently? As a kid, I remember asking my mom what prayer was and she had a helpful response: prayer is a conversation with God.

When we pray, we are entering into a conversation with God. We are building up and engaging in a relationship with God. We are living out our deep desire to grow closer to God and to receive what God longs to give all of us: God's unconditional love, which is always available, always freely offered, and always life-giving.

Another helpful way of understanding prayer comes from the Jesuit theologian Walter Burghardt, who once expressed contemplation/prayer as "taking a long, loving look at the real." Let's break this definition down into parts.

First, prayer begins with taking a *long* look. It's looking at reality like slow-motion cameras at a sporting event. We get the chance to slow down and to take a closer look, which may reveal to us things we might have otherwise missed in our fast-paced lives.

Second, prayer is also a long, *loving* look. When I reflect on reality, do I look with harsh, judgmental eyes, or with the loving, tender, and merciful eyes of God?

Lastly, in prayer we look lovingly at *the real*: the reality of my life and the world. We start with reality because God does so through the Incarnation. God undertakes the work of salvation not by fleeing human reality, but by entering into it. In the ultimate act of solidarity, God became one of us in the person

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So prayer is a conversation with God. This understanding of prayer gives me both a great sense of freedom...and nervousness.

I feel free because prayer does not have to be a formula. I don't have to "have it all together" when I take time to pray. In fact, sometimes I may not know what to say at all. I may be at a complete loss for words. Thankfully the Church has collected and provided prayers over its long history to help us express to God the deepest parts of our heart. Just think of the Our Father, given to us by Jesus himself. Or the Hail Mary. These prayers remind us of Jesus' reassurance to be direct in what we are seeking and that sometimes we don't need to use so many words.

But I also feel nervous about prayer, since prayer is not limited to following a single formula. All kinds of doubts and questions can come to my mind. "Am I doing this right?" "Does God really care about what I have to share?" "My life isn't as bad as others. God has enough to deal with." But where are these feelings coming from? Certainly not from God! We know that God wants to be in relationship with us, and always welcomes our prayers.

So let's not forget the other side of this relationship. If prayer is supposed to be a conversation, we need to remember that it should include both speaking *and* listening. This may seem obvious, but how often do we forget it! How often do I jump into prayer just to list all the intentions I have and the people I want to pray for, and then I end with a sign of the cross and move on!

Prayer, then, is the courage to listen to the gentle voice of love. Listening means allowing God space to speak to us: through the quiet of prayer, in our own deep desires, through



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There is no simple formula for praying, but here are a few tips for preparing yourself to enter into prayer.

First, what we do before praying is very important. Usually it's not helpful to rush into prayer. Perhaps spend a few moments quieting down and settling into a prayerful and comfortable position.

Second, finding a good, comfortable space where you are free of distractions can make a real difference. Silence and solitude can help us focus on reading a Scripture passage, or looking back on moments from my day/life, and then reflect on how God may be speaking to me through them. A quiet place can help with that deeper listening to God's presence, as well as notice our response.

Lastly, let's admit that we might not always be able to set up for a good prayer period. We might not have time to quiet down and find a good, comfortable space. But we can trust that God meets us where we are. That means God can speak to us in the noise and confusion of our day. If you only have time to stop for a moment, call to mind God's presence, and speak a petition...that's prayer. And God delights in it!



Methods of Prayer

Over the centuries, the Christian understanding of prayer has developed and deepened. Through all those years, the Catholic Church has discovered that there's no one-size-fits-all method of prayer. As a result, several different methods of prayer have been experienced and developed, which countless numbers of people have benefitted from in their journey of faith.

Here are a few classic methods of prayer that you might want to investigate more and consider putting into practice in your own prayer life.

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contemplating Scripture or other texts.

- [Centering Prayer](#): We focus silently on a sacred word that prepares us to receive the gift of contemplative prayer, prayer in which we experience God's presence within us.
- [Ignatian Contemplation](#): We use our imagination to place ourselves in a scene from Scripture using all our senses and take notice of how God may be speaking to us.
- [The Ignatian Examen](#): An opportunity for us to prayerfully review our day in the presence of God.

When I was a novice about to start my 30-day silent retreat doing the *Spiritual Exercises of St. Ignatius of Loyola*, my Director of Novices encouraged me to start each prayer period by first imagining God gazing upon me with loving eyes. And he said to do this for the length of an "Our Father" (which, said at a gentle pace, can be about 30 seconds). That was the context from which everything else flowed.

Prayer is about being in relationship with God. It's not always easy, but it can be full of grace. When we take a long, loving look at the real we have the opportunity to behold ourselves and the world as God does—with tender mercy, compassion, and love. Knowing the truth of God's love for us in prayer can be a game-changer.

God is always reaching out to us. Prayer is our response.

Born and raised in southern California, David Romero, SJ received a BA in Theology from Loyola Marymount University, where he experienced several opportunities to live a life of faith and justice. These experiences led him to study abroad as a junior with the Casa de la Solidaridad program in El Salvador, which kick-started his discernment to enter the Jesuits upon graduation. He completed his



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